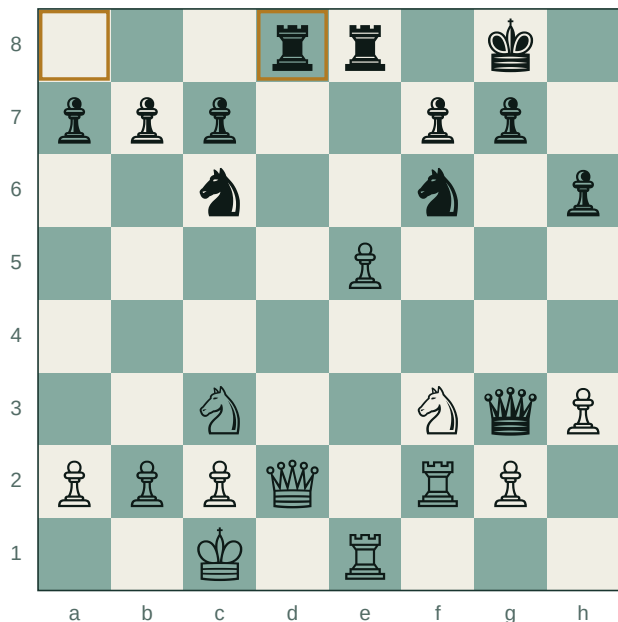


Intermediate moves: White, move 19

Intermediate moves

White to move



Previous move: 18...Rad8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

19. exf6 Rxd2 20. Rxe8+ Kh7 21. Rxd2

19.exf6 The pawn captures the knight on f6. The changed line means the rook on e1 attacks the rook on e8. Recorded reply: **19...Rxd2**.

20.Rxe8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the rook on e8. Recorded reply: **20...Kh7**.

21.Rxd2 The rook captures the rook on d2.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 18 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +4: the balance goes from +0 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: queen on g3. Check for tactical protection.